THE THINGS I CALLED FRIENDSHIP

CHARACTERS

VALERIE Sixteen or seventeen. Outgoing, funny, and seemingly carefree. She is the "party queen" in school, someone who looks confident in a crowd, but underneath she is sensitive, insecure, and afraid of being abandoned. Through her relationship with Lauren, she slowly begins to realize that her feelings are more than friendship.

VALERIE (30) Thirty years old. An artist who looks back on her teenage years through her paintings. She is calmer and more reflective than her younger self, but the memories of that summer still affect her deeply. As the narrator of the play, she guides the audience through her past and tries to understand the younger version of herself.

LAUREN Sixteen or seventeen. Sharp, awkward, humorous, and emotionally guarded. She often uses jokes or avoidance to escape serious feelings, but she cares deeply about Valerie. She wants closeness, but is afraid of being labeled, exposed, or trapped by the relationship.

MOTHER Valerie's mother. Strict, anxious, and deeply concerned with social judgment. She believes she is protecting Valerie, but her fear of what is "abnormal" becomes a source of pressure and pain for her daughter.

FATHER Valerie's father. Emotionally distant and often absent, even when he is physically present. He avoids conflict and fails to provide Valerie with the emotional support she needs at home.

CHORUS AS STUDENTS A group of students who represent the school environment, peer pressure, gossip, and social judgment. They create the atmosphere of teenage life: lively and energetic, but also cruel, careless, and full of invisible rules.

WANG A student in the cafeteria scene. His interaction with William shows the immaturity and casual homophobia that exist in the school environment.

WILLIAM A loud and aggressive student. His jokes and comments reveal how easily teenagers use sexuality as an insult or a way to shame others.

ELLIOTT A student who challenges the unfairness of the boys' comments in the cafeteria. His words expose the double standards and social pressure around same-sex relationships.

FIRST PERSON / SECOND PERSON Audience voices in the epilogue. They appear during Valerie's gallery Q&A and help connect the past story with Valerie's present life as an artist.

TEXT

PROLOGUE Thirty-Year-Old Valerie

Night. An art studio. Unfinished paintings lean against the wall—scenes of the ocean, a school hallway, and a blurry dance floor.

VALERIE, thirty, stands center stage, looking directly at the audience. Her posture is relaxed but intentional.

[Lights.]

VALERIE(30) The people who come to these gallery shows always ask me about the deep meaning behind my art. They look at these canvases and try to analyze my intentions and techniques, writing it off as some poetic exploration of youth. To them, it's just a pleasant illusion.

But honestly? I'm the opposite of a stage magician. A magician gives you an illusion that looks like the truth. I'm standing here trying to do the exact opposite. I'm trying to give you a raw, painful truth disguised as a pretty painting. There are no deep concepts here.

To begin with, I'm just turning back time. 【Music slows as time begins to reverse】 Reversing it to a specific, miserable summer. And not the pretty kind you see on travel posters. I mean the hot, sticky kind where the air smells like rain, school uniforms stick to your back, and half the lights in the hallway are broken. I was sixteen or seventeen. 【Party music】 I don't even remember the exact year anymore.

Music begins faintly. Justin Bibber's "Beauty and a Beat" rises from memory. The studio lights fade into the school dance.

VALERIE (30) And then... she looked right at me.

Blackout into the past.

SCENE ONE

Party of Acquaintance

CHORUS AS STUDENTS OH MY GOD THIS SONG!
CHORUS AS STUDENTS TURN IT UP!
CHORUS AS STUDENTS I LOVE THIS SONG!
CHORUS AS STUDENTS EVERYBODY DANCE!
CHORUS AS STUDENTS Valerie, Party queen!

Lights find VALERIE.

She is in the middle of the room.

She is laughing.

She is bright.

The kind of bright that makes other people feel invited.

LAUREN stands near the wall.

Chorus as students pulls her to the middle of the stage

VALERIE senses that the attention once focused on her has shifted to LAUREN, so she turns to see what kind of girl she is.

VALERIE Hi.
LAUREN Hi.
VALERIE Come on.
LAUREN No.
I don't dance.
VALERIE Nobody here dances. Look.
LAUREN I don't know anyone.
VALERIE You know me.
LAUREN I have known you for forty seconds.
I'm going to look stupid.
VALERIE Yes.
But next to me, no one will notice.

Lauren looks at Valerie.

For the first time, really looks.

The flashing lights catch Valerie's face again.

She is sweaty from dancing.

A little ridiculous.

Completely unashamed.

VALERIE(30) I think this was the first thing she gave me.
Not friendship.
Permission.
VALERIE You're doing great.
LAUREN I'm not doing anything.
VALERIE You just doing great!
CHORUS AS STUDENTS 1 They have the same face.
CHORUS AS STUDENTS 2 Same energy though.
CHORUS AS STUDENTS 3 Velerie is louder.
CHORUS AS STUDENTS 4 Valerie looks like Lauren if Lauren read books.
LAUREN I can read!

CHORUS AS STUDENT 1 Name one book.

Lauren freezes.

Valerie looks at her.

VALERIE Dictionary.

LAUREN Yes. Thank you. My favourite novel. You just saved my academic reputation.

Lights fade on them dancing badly together.

Blackout.

VALERIE(30) After that night, she started tracking me down almost every day, turning all that loud, uninvited energy into my daily routine. I didn't think there was a single spot on campus where I could actually be left alone.

She looks toward the art room set

Except, of course, for the art room.

SCENE TWO

ACT 1: Art Room

Blackout from the dance. Music fades. A school bell rings. Students cross the stage. Lights settle on the art room.

Late afternoon.

Valerie sits alone, drawing.

VALERIE(30) The art room was the first place in school where nobody expected me to explain myself.

A beat.

VALERIE(30) So of course Lauren found me there.

Lauren appears at the door.

LAUREN Am I interrupting?

VALERIE Maybe.

LAUREN Can I come in?

Valerie nods.

Lauren sits beside her.

The silence isn't awkward.

LAUREN Can I see?

VALERIE It's not finished.

LAUREN Most things aren't.

LAUREN I like it.

It feels peaceful.

VALERIE That's not much of a comment.

LAUREN It's honest.

A pause.

VALERIE You're not going to ask what it means?

LAUREN Do you want me to?

VALERIE No.

LAUREN Then I won't.

Valerie relaxes.

Lauren points to the page.

LAUREN Can I add something?

VALERIE Why?

LAUREN So I'll know I was here.

She laughs.

LAUREN Artistically.

Valerie hands her the pencil.

Lauren held her hand directly.

VALERIE You changed it.

LAUREN Only a little.
Still yours.
Just...less lonely.

Valerie looks at the page.

Then at Lauren.

Something quietly changes

VALERIE(30) I never thought I would never let anyone touch my paintings. I also never expected that we become this close.

ACT 2: Dorm

Evening study.

Valerie is explaining a math problem to Lauren that Lauren doesn't know how to solve.

Lauren lies on the bed playing a game.

VALERIE Move that term across.

LAUREN Why?

VALERIE You need to isolate x.

LAUREN Poor x.

Valerie looks up.

Lauren isn't looking at the board.

She's looking at the phone.

Still focus on her video game.

VALERIE Are you looking at the phone or me?

LAUREN Both.
Valerie feigning anger.

LAUREN I'm serious.
I want better grades.
I want us to study in the same country.
Maybe even live together.

Valerie sits up.

LAUREN We'd travel.
Go to markets.
Try food we can't pronounce.

VALERIE You'd pronounce it confidently wrong anyway.

LAUREN Exactly.

LAUREN walks to the whiteboard and draws an abstract sketch of the Eiffel Tower, asking VALERIE to guess where it is.

VALERIE Paris?

LAUREN Yes.

VALERIE Japan?

LAUREN For the temples.
...And the vending machines.

Valerie laughs.

LAUREN We'll buy a map.
Red pins for where we've been.
Blue for where we're going.
Yellow for every time you get annoyed at me.

VALERIE We'll need a lot of yellow pins.

LAUREN Bulk order.

Lauren holds out her pinky.

LAUREN Promise?

Valerie hooks hers around it.

VALERIE Promise.

A beat.

VALERIE(30) From that day on, we were inseparable. Best friends in the truest sense. That is, until the day we heard the voices .... and everything shattered.

ACT 3: Cafeteria

Students fill the lunchroom.

Lauren opens Valerie's lunch.

VALERIE That's mine.

LAUREN I know.

She looks inside.

LAUREN Scallions.

Again.

Lauren immediately starts picking them out.

VALERIE You don't have to.

LAUREN I know.

I'm still doing it.

VALERIE(30) Say stop.

Say thank you.

Don't sound like you needed it.

Valerie watches.

VALERIE You remembered.

LAUREN You told me on the second day.

"Scallions are a vegetable pretending to be an opinion."

Valerie laughs.

VALERIE That sounds like me.

Lauren finishes.

LAUREN Safe.

WANG Hey, mind if I sit here?

ELLIOTT Go for it.

WANG Did you watch the play this morning?

ELLIOTT Yeah. Ms. Gong told me about it.

It was amazing.

William enter

William is returning his lunch tray.

WILLIAM Yo, what the hell are you two doing?

WANG Bro, shut up. Why are you always so damn loud?

WILLIAM What do you mean, bro? I'm fucking saving your life, you knucklehead.

WANG Bro, you gotta chill, man.

WILLIAM How can I chill? Get your bitch ass over here.

Look at you, man, standing there like you don't know shit.

But you do.

You do, you stupid.

WANG Bro, chill dude.

Chelax, chelax, chelax, chelax, chelax.

WILLIAM Type shit, bro, then stop being gay, you cool ass fucker.

Looking like you're gonna be gay next second.

Man—

Improvising.

WANG Okay, okay, okay, okay, okay.

The argument gets quieter as they move farther away.

William drags Wang away from Elliott.

ELLIOTT Hey!
You sons of bitches, open your eyes and look around.
Two lesbians are sitting together, even sharing food.
Why aren't you giving them shit?
But two guys sit together and chat for two minutes, and suddenly everyone's got something to say?

WILLIAM 'Cause you're gay, bro.

ELLIOTT Seriously?
What kind of prehistoric logic is that?
What century are you guys living in?
Go find something to do, bro.

Elliott walks over to Lauren and Valerie.

ELLIOTT Hey, Valerie and Lauren.
I hope you stay together forever.
Unlike us...

VALERIE(30) At this time we were only at the age of 16 /17 and we were really immature.
Some kinds of care sound ridiculous when you say them out loud.
Saving someone a seat.
Picking out a piece of scallion.
But when you're sixteen, those things matter.
And...Until, a school trip to Thailand kinda shifted our relationship.

Lights fade.

Blackout.

SCENE THREE

Thailand

ACT 1: The Beach

Waves.

Blue light.

The school disappears.

Only the sea.

VALERIE and LAUREN sit side by side.

Close.

Not touching.

VALERIE Thailand made us anonymous.

A beat.

VALERIE No one knew us here.
No one knew anything about us.

A beat.

VALERIE We weren't a rumor.
Just two girls by the sea.
Lauren drinks, then immediately grimaces.

LAUREN This drink attacked me.

VALERIE You bought it.

LAUREN Still violent.

Valerie smells it.

VALERIE Candy and regret.

LAUREN Exactly.

A silence.

LAUREN You're quiet.

VALERIE Everything feels different here.
Back home, everything has rules.
Here… nothing does.

LAUREN So what are we?

VALERIE I don't know.

A beat.

VALERIE(30) I thought wanting would be clear.
It wasn't.
It came as panic.
As her becoming too important too fast.
I didn't know what it meant.
Only that I didn't want it to stop.
Lauren draws in the sand.

VALERIE I know you.
But not what hurts you.

A beat.

LAUREN I don't know what people do with feelings.

VALERIE They listen.

LAUREN And then?

VALERIE That's enough.

A beat.

Lauren looks away.

LAUREN I learned not to say things.
Lonely things.
Wanting things.
So I made everything small.

VALERIE Does it help?
Lauren doesn't answer.

VALERIE Can I tell you something?
My parents aren't in love.
I thought love was something people stopped doing.

A beat.

VALERIE Then there's this girl.
And I don't know what I am when I think about her.
Only that I don't want to lose her.

A beat.

VALERIE What if something's wrong with me?

LAUREN Nothing is wrong with you.

A beat.

LAUREN If your heart moves toward someone, it isn't broken.

VALERIE And if I ruin it?

LAUREN Then we go slowly.
They sit.
Their shoulders almost touch.

VALERIE Slowly.

Waves continue.

Lights shift.

ACT 2: The Hotel Room

Small hotel room.

Queensized bed , Suitcase half open. Wet towels. Humid air. Shower running faintly in the background.

VALERIE enters from the bathroom, hair damp, in sleep clothes. LAUREN lies face down on the bed, still in beach clothes, exhausted.

VALERIE Are you planning to sleep like that?

LAUREN Yes.

VALERIE You still have sand on you.

LAUREN The sand and I have reached an understanding.

VALERIE Go shower.

LAUREN I've already showered spiritually.

VALERIE That's not a thing.

LAUREN It is in my culture.

VALERIE Which culture?

LAUREN The culture of being tired.

VALERIE stares at her. LAUREN groans and rolls off the bed.

Shower starts. VALERIE alone. She looks at both beds. Then the narrow space between them.

VALERIE(30) Hotel rooms are honest in a way people aren't.

They show you exactly how close things are.

CHROUS breath

Beat.

VALERIE (30) I kept trying to organize everything. The suitcase. The towels. Even the space between the beds. As if order could make feeling behave. But nothing did.

Shower stops. LAUREN enters

Hair wet, oversized clothes, towel thrown badly over her head.

Valerie picks up the hairdryer from the desk.

VALERIE Move.

LAUREN No.

VALERIE I'm drying your hair.

LAUREN I refuse medical treatment.

VALERIE This is not medical treatment.

LAUREN Then why does it feel threatening?

VALERIE Because you are dramatic.

Lauren turns her head slightly, cheek pressed to the pillow.

LAUREN Fine.

A beat.

LAUREN But if you burn me, I will haunt you.

VALERIE Noted.

VALERIE (30) There are things you can lie about in language. Friend. Normal. Nothing happening. But the body does not learn language properly. My hands knew before I did. So I called it taking care of her.

VALERIE turns on the hairdryer. LAUREN relaxes immediately.

LAUREN You're good at this.

VALERIE Drying hair?

LAUREN Taking care of people.

VALERIE pauses slightly.

LAUREN Do you like me or something?

Beat. VALERIE freezes.

VALERIE Don't flatter yourself.

Later. Lights dim. Both in bed. The room is almost dark.

LAUREN lies beside VALERIE. Close. Not touching at first.

VALERIE (30) I told myself not to move. Not because I didn't feel it. Because moving would mean I had admitted it. And admitting it meant everything would have a name. And I wasn't ready for names.

LAUREN Are you asleep?

VALERIE Yes.

LAUREN You answer very quickly for someone asleep.

VALERIE I'm gifted.

LAUREN I knew that.

Silence. Soft.

VALERIE Lauren?

LAUREN Yeah?

VALERIE What do you think a girl dating with another girl?

LAUREN You're the most important person in my life.

VALERIE's breath changes.

LAUREN Good night.

VALERIE turns slightly closer into the space between them.

VALERIE Good night.

Silence. Their breathing slows.

VALERIE (30) That night, nothing became clear. Only closer. I learned that friendship was the word I used when I didn't know how to tell the truth. And that my body had already told it for me.

Waves faintly return.

BLACKOUT.

SCENE FOUR

The House With Quiet Rooms

Home.

A dining table.

A half-unpacked suitcase.

A presentation board or laptop screen nearby.

FATHER passes through the room with his phone in his hand.

MOTHER What are we going to do about the child?

FATHER I have a call.

MOTHER Again?

FATHER exits to take the call.

A door closes somewhere.

VALERIE is near the table. MOTHER notices the poster.

MOTHER What is this?

A beat.

MOTHER "Sexual Minorities"?

A beat.

MOTHER What kind of thing is this?

MOTHER It's a research project for school.

MOTHER School?

A beat.

MOTHER Your school is teaching you to research things like this now?

MOTHER What on earth is your school teaching you all day?

VALERIE does not answer.

MOTHER Let me make this clear first. What other people do is their freedom. I can't control that.

A beat.

MOTHER But you must never get involved with things like this.

VALERIE ……

...

MOTHER Do you know how people in society look at people like that?

MOTHER Wherever they go, people will gossip about them and point fingers at them. They'll never be able to hold their heads up.

MOTHER What about your future job? What about marriage? What will people think of our family?

A beat.

MOTHER Don't think I'm being harsh. This is reality.

MOTHER I don't care what other people's children do, but my daughter can never become like that.

VALERIE stays silent.

MOTHER Did you hear me?

VALERIE Yeah.

MOTHER You'd better really take it in.

A silence.

MOTHER turns away and sees the suitcase.

MOTHER How long have you been back? Why haven't you unpacked your suitcase yet?

VALERIE I will. Soon.

MOTHER You always say that to me.

MOTHER Every time, I find dirty clothes and dirty socks in your bag.

MOTHER How many times has this happened? You still haven't changed.

She folds a piece of clothing too sharply.

A beat.

MOTHER Was Thailand fun?

VALERIE It was okay.

MOTHER How did you get so tanned after one trip?

VALERIE Who goes on vacation and doesn't get tanned?

MOTHER Don't speak to me with that attitude.

A beat.

MOTHER Is that how you talk to your parents?

MOTHER I was just asking you nicely.

VALERIE looks away.

MOTHER When you were on the trip, were you with that girl the whole time?

VALERIE A lot of people went.

MOTHER A lot of people went, but that doesn't mean I'm asking about a lot of people.

A beat.

VALERIE Lauren

Lauren.

Yeah. We were in the same group.

MOTHER You two are really close now.

MOTHER She's in the photos, she's with you at meals, she's sitting with you on the bus. You two are together all the time.

MOTHER Are you two doing everything together now, except sleeping?

VALERIE We're just friends.

A beat.

MOTHER Friends?

A beat.

MOTHER I'm telling you, it's exactly this kind of "just friends" that eventually turns into those messy relationships.

VALERIE Mom.

MOTHER Stay away from her. I don't want people talking behind our backs, wondering whether there's something wrong with my daughter.

VALERIE What are you trying to say?

MOTHER Haven't I made myself clear enough? What does it look like for a girl to be with another girl? Do you think people will understand you? They'll only think you're abnormal. You could live a perfectly normal life, but instead you insist on turning yourself into an outsider. I don't care what other people's children do, but my daughter cannot.

FATHER enters from another room, still holding his phone.

FATHER Okok, I will send you later bye.

A beat.

FATHER Bye.

He hangs up.

FATHER What are you two arguing about so late at night?

A beat.

VALERIE & MOTHER None of your business!

VALERIE looks at FATHER, then at MOTHER.

VALERIE Do you and Dad really love each other?

MOTHER turns sharply.

MOTHER Why are you worrying about so much at your age?

MOTHER What kind of question is that?

VALERIE Why can't we ever talk properly?

A beat.

VALERIE You barely talk to him.

VALERIE points toward FATHER.

VALERIE Whenever you two talk, you start fighting, so you just stop talking and avoid each other.

A beat.

VALERIE Is that what you call love?

MOTHER You'll understand when you have your own family. There's no way to explain it to you now.

MOTHER And also, you'd better remember what I told you before.

VALERIE What?

MOTHER Stay away from Lauren.

MOTHER I don't want to see you two stuck together every day anymore.

MOTHER People may not say it out loud, but inside, they'll all think there's something wrong with you.

MOTHER When that happens, you won't be the only one embarrassed. Our whole family will be embarrassed too.

VALERIE What does it mean to have something wrong with me? What does abnormal even mean?

A beat.

MOTHER Normal is normal. Abnormal is abnormal.

MOTHER This is just how society is. You can't change it by yourself.

VALERIE I said I'll make my own decisions.

A beat.

VALERIE I don't need you to control me.

MOTHER There's one more thing.

VALERIE stops.

MOTHER Your father and I have been discussing it recently.

A beat.

MOTHER We think it's time to give you a new environment.

VALERIE turns back.

VALERIE What do you mean?

MOTHER Change schools.
Go abroad.

VALERIE Why?

VALERIE Why now?

MOTHER You don't need to ask so many questions.

A beat.

MOTHER I just think your current environment isn't doing you any good.

MOTHER Change your environment, meet new people, and maybe things will slowly get better.

VALERIE ……
...

MOTHER Your father and I will arrange this.
We're not discussing it with you.
We're just informing you.

Silence.

Blackout.

SCENE FIVE

Roof Top

Night.

The school rooftop.

VALERIE sits alone on the edge, her silhouette sharp against the city lights.

She is deathly still.

LAUREN bursts through the heavy metal door, breathless, wrapping her jacket tighter around herself against the wind.

LAUREN Hello?
So, you invited me here.
You text me at midnight telling me it's an emergency.
So..?

VALERIE
Without turning around
I don't know.

LAUREN
Exasperated
You keep saying that.
Every time I ask you anything lately, it's just 'I don't know.'

VALERIE Because I don't!

LAUREN Then why am I here?

You can't just summon me to the top of the school in the middle of the night and then sit there like a ghost.

VALERIE I just wanted to see you.

LAUREN That's not an answer.

I'm trying, okay?

I'm here, I'm listening, but you're speaking in riddles.

You keep talking like I'm supposed to understand some big, hidden secret that you refuse to actually say out loud.

VALERIE

Slowly turning her head, voice tight

Because I am saying it, Lauren.

I've been screaming it for months, but you just put your hands over your ears and pretend it's just background noise.

LAUREN Screaming what?

What are you even talking about?

VALERIE

Taking a step forward

School, Lauren!

Look down there.

That building.

You think it's just a normal place?

Every morning I walk through those front doors and it feels like walking into an execution.

You don't see the way the girls in the locker room shuffle away when I sit down?

You don't hear the whispers that stop the second I walk into a bathroom stall?

They look at me like I'm a disease.

Like whatever 'wrong' thing is inside of me might be contagious.

LAUREN People talk, Valerie!

They're high school idiots, they've always been cruel, you can't let them get under your skin….

VALERIE

Voice rising, interrupting

Oh, so I should just ignore it?

Is that your brilliant advice?

Just like I should ignore my own home?

Have you been to my house lately, Lauren?

Have you felt the air in there?

My mother doesn't even look at my face anymore.

She thinks I am ruined.

LAUREN

Defensive, overwhelmed by the intensity

I know it's terrible at your house, and I'm sorry!

I hate that she does that to you.

But what do you want me to do about your mother?

I am not her!

I can't change how she thinks!

VALERIE

Stepping directly into Lauren's space, eyes burning

No, but you could have changed how I felt.

But instead, you became part of it.

The society, the rumors, the stares….. you joined them.

LAUREN

Shocked

I did not!

How can you say that?

VALERIE Because they hate me from a distance, Lauren, but you….. y you destroy me from right next to me.

Every single time someone points a finger at us, you drop my hand like it's made of fire.

Every time someone asks you if we were hanging out over the weekend, you laugh it off and call me a 'family friend.'

You watch me drown in their judgment every single day, and you just stand on the shore, completely dry, completely untouched.

You pretend you don't see the blood on the floor just so you can keep your own hands clean!

LAUREN

Angry, tears of frustration forming

Because I am terrified, Valerie!

You think you're the only one trapped in this?

You're dragging me into a fire I didn't start!

I have a life too!

I have parents who expect things from me, I have a future to think about!

I can't just set my whole world on fire just to keep you warm!

VALERIE

Screaming

I didn't ask you to burn!

I just asked you to stand next to me!

But you've already chosen, haven't you?

Your body is standing on this rooftop, but your heart left weeks ago.

You've already abandoned me to save yourself!

LAUREN

Screaming back, losing control

YOU ARE BEING UNFAIR!

You're putting the weight of the whole world on my shoulders!

You're looking at me like if I don't say the exact right words, I'm the monster in your story!

What do you actually want from me?!

Tell me!

What do you want me to say?!

VALERIE

Screaming through tears, her whole body shaking

I want you to admit it!

Admit that you know why they're whispering!

Admit that you see me!

the real me ! …and that you care!

LAUREN I DO SEE YOU!

VALERIE THEN WHY ARE YOU LEAVING ME TO DIE IN THIS ALONE?!

LAUREN

Gasping for air, furious, desperate, face flushed

BECAUSE I DON'T KNOW WHAT WE ARE, VALERIE!

You demand everything from me, you want my whole life, but you haven't given me a single name for it!

You want me to risk everything, but you won't even say the words!

So say it!

If you're going to destroy us tonight anyway, just say the fucking words!

The wind howls softly between them.

Both of them are breathing hard, trembling with pure adrenaline and raw emotion.

Lauren is shaking, staring at Valerie, waiting for the final blow.

Valerie's chest heaves.

Slowly, the rage in her eyes completely collapses, leaving only a devastating, naked vulnerability.

VALERIE

Quietly, shattering the silence

I love you.

Lauren freezes.

The air leaves her lungs.

VALERIE

A soft whisper, heavy and certain

I love you.

Lauren opens her mouth to defend herself, to say something, but no sound comes out.

She looks at Valerie, utterly paralyzed, her mouth trembling.

VALERIE

Tears finally spilling over

You are already part of my life.

I can't live without you.

Valerie takes a slow, shaky breath, wiping her face, and looks out at the distant city skyline, her voice dropping into a flat, haunting calm.

VALERIE My bags are already packed.

I'm leaving tomorrow.

BLACKOUT

EPILOGUE

Thirty-Year-Old Valerie's Studio

VALERIE(30) ...And yeah, that's pretty much the whole story behind the pieces. No big, hidden concepts, just a lot of old feelings. But look, I know you guys always have thoughts, so let's do a quick Q&A. Ask me anything. Don't be shy.

A brief silence. Voices rise from the dimness of the audience played by the ENSEMBLE. Their tones are conversational and curious, like journalists or friends at a laid-back interview.

First person

From the left side of the audience; curious, relaxed

Hey Valerie. So, if that summer was actually as miserable as you say it was, why keep painting it? Why choose to trap yourself inside a broken school hallway over and over again?

VALERIE(30)

Nodding with an easy smile, speaking genuinely

Because a canvas is the only place where things don't change. Life moves way too fast, but here, I can make a moment stay completely still. Even if it stings a little to look at, it's safe.

Second person

From the right side of the audience; leaning forward in interest

What about the way you paint people? Are you deliberately trying to hide her identity, or is there a different reason?

VALERIE(30)

She smiles, casually waving her hand to wrap things up

Probably not...emmm...

LAUREN(30) Actually I have a question.
How are you? Recently

BLACKOUT.

[END OF PLAY]